Over the years, the threat on the Northern Front kept increasing. In fact, as far back as 1998, the then RM, Shri George Fernandes, was the first person, breaking years of taboo, to publicly identify China as the Number 1 threat.[9] Keeping that in mind, infrastructure development and force accretions for the Northern Front were undertaken. The road network was extended albeit at a slow pace due to delays in clearances from various Ministries. Two additional Divisions (56 Inf Div and 71 Inf Div) were raised in the period 2009–12 for 3 Corps and 4 Corps respectively.[10] During this period, study groups were constituted for planning the creation of a Mountain Strike Corps, and I was a part of one such group. In July 2013, the CCS approved the creation of a Mountain Strike Corps, which resulted in the raising of 17 Corps in January 2014.[11] Yet, despite these accretions, the bias of the Army remained towards the Western Front.

Of the total of 14 x Corps, comprising some forty-odd Divisions and Independent Brigades, approximately 9 x Corps (70 per cent), and thirty-plus Divisions (75 per cent) catered for the Western Front of 3300-odd km. In comparison, only 4 x Corps (30 per cent) and only 9 x Divisions (25 per cent) catered for the more inhospitable Northern Front of over 4000 km. It was evident that the troop density was totally inadequate to meet even a low-level threat. After the Doklam crisis of 2019, some individual units, mostly artillery and air defence, were moved from the West to the East, but did this not materially affect the force ratios. The three Strike Corps (1, 2 and 21) were all earmarked for the Western Front. 17 Corps had to look after the whole of the Northern Front, from Ladakh in the North, through the Central Sector, all the way to Arunachal Pradesh in the East. This was just not practical.

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